

How are we to live?

Ages 11-16

*Evidence-based pointers on living well —
each with its study design, its effect size, and its honest
weakness.*

Trust but verify

"Trust but verify" is an old phrase, and it is the whole method of this site. It means: don't be a cynic who believes nothing, and don't be a pushover who believes everything — **believe things in proportion to the evidence, and go look at the evidence yourself.**

So every health page here comes with its workings on show:

Trust but verify (cont.)

- **How good the evidence is** — a badge on each page says plainly how strong or shaky the proof is, and the page names its own weakest point. A page that hid its weaknesses would be doing exactly what we criticise.
- **Which clock it's on** — another badge marks whether a risk is mostly a near-term one (the next ten years) or a lifetime one (the next seventy), because that changes how much it should matter to you right now.
- **The actual sources** — the studies are named so you can look them up. You don't have to; the point is that you *could*.

Trust but verify (cont.)

Information is power in a very literal sense: a lot of products are designed to be easy to start and hard to stop, and they work best on people who never check the evidence. Checking is the move that puts you back in charge.

Smoking kills, stopping helps

If you look at what actually harms people your age in this country, smoking is not near the top. The things most likely to seriously hurt or kill a teenager are **accidents — especially on the roads — and self-harm**. Cigarettes belong to a much slower clock: they mostly harm people decades from now.

But your teens are exactly when that slow clock gets *started*, and it is exactly when nicotine gets sold to you — now mostly as vapes. So two honest things at once:

Smoking kills, stopping helps (cont.)

- **Vaping nicotine is not the same as smoking.** Cigarettes harm you by *burning* — the smoke is full of the chemicals that do the long-term damage. A vape does not burn, so it delivers far fewer of those chemicals. Anyone who tells you a vape is "just as bad as a cigarette" is wrong, and once you know that, you will stop trusting the rest of what they say. That is why being straight with you matters.
- **But for someone who has never smoked, starting to vape is pure loss.** You would be taking on an addiction with nothing to trade for it — vapes have only existed since around 2007, so nobody can honestly promise you they are safe over a lifetime, because that lifetime hasn't happened yet.

Smoking kills, stopping helps (cont.)

What you do now bends the whole rest of the line. **Not starting removes almost the entire future risk, at no cost to you.**

It is the single highest-value health decision available to you — and the leverage is highest right now, precisely because this is when the addiction is designed to catch you.

And if someone you love already smokes, this matters for them too: quitting is genuinely hard, but it is **not** just willpower.

Proper help — medicines plus support — makes success far more likely, and it is never too late. They do not have to do it alone.

Alcohol: no safe dose

Here is the thing the lifetime-cancer statistics miss: for someone your age, **the risk from alcohol is tonight, not thirty years away.** The real dangers are immediate and physical — injury, being hurt in a fight, drowning, choking, passing out, and things that get done to you or by you that cannot be taken back. That is a completely different, and much closer, kind of harm than liver disease decades from now.

Alcohol: no safe dose (cont.)

One honest point to hold onto: **there is no amount of alcohol that is good for you** — the idea that "a glass of red wine is healthy" turned out to be a mistake in how the old studies were built. But be fair about size too: for an adult, the extra risk from *one* drink is small. The problem is the shape of the line, not usually the size of one drink.

What you do now bends the line later — but the more useful message for you is the near one: the danger you can actually see coming is same-night, not same-lifetime.

Gambling: designed so you lose

The most dangerous gambling products are the ones **on your phone**, and they are designed that way on purpose: fast, endless, always open, a new bet every few seconds. Speed and continuity are what make a product hard to stop, and plenty of people your age are already in the data.

Here is the unanswerable part, and why this one needs no complicated science:

Gambling: designed so you lose (cont.)

- **The "house edge" is published.** For a game like roulette or an online slot, the company literally states, in the terms, what fraction of all the money bet it will keep. It is a guarantee, not a guess.
- So the honest line is: **you are not unlucky — you are on the wrong side of a number the company chose in advance, wrote down, and published.** Nobody has to cheat you. The edge is in the terms and conditions.

Gambling: designed so you lose (cont.)

What you do now matters because the habit, and the harm, track the *product*, not your personality — the faster and more constant the game, the more people it hurts. The defence is not out-willpowering a well-built machine; it is declining to play a game whose maths you have now seen.

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much.

Two blunt facts first, because they are the point:

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much. (cont.)

- **Excess body fat causes disease.** It is not just a look — higher body fat *causally* raises your risk of type 2 diabetes, heart disease and several cancers, and shortens life on average. This is one of the better-evidenced things on the whole site (genetic studies back it up, so it is not just correlation).
- **The biggest risk factor for carrying excess weight later is carrying it now.** Weight tracks hard from childhood into adulthood, and once the body has gained fat it *defends* it — after weight loss, metabolism drops and the weight tends to come back. Reversal is genuinely hard; prevention is far easier.

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much. (cont.)

Put those together and the useful move is obvious: **don't get there in the first place** — and that is far more about your environment than your willpower. The amount you eat is partly a property of the food itself: in the best experiment on this, the same people ate a lot more when the food was processed, without trying to. It is also a property of *how much is put in front of you* — give people bigger portions and they reliably eat more, without feeling any fuller. So the levers you actually control are upstream of hunger — what is in the kitchen, what is easiest to grab, and how big the serving is (a smaller plate, not seconds by habit). Change the defaults and the eating changes with them.

Move more, sit less

The science here is genuinely encouraging:

- The single biggest gain on the whole curve is **moving out of the least-active group**. If you do almost nothing now, a little regular movement buys you more than a very-fit person gains by training even harder.
- The useful dose is **lower than most people think**. Most of the benefit arrives well before any big daily target.

Move more, sit less (cont.)

So there is nothing you have to "hit" and no membership to buy. Whatever movement you can tolerate — a sport, a walk, a bike ride — captures most of what matters. What you build now is a habit that keeps paying off for decades, but even judged on today it is the most winnable item on this whole site.

Move more, sit less (cont.)

And the payoff is not only decades away. Regular activity is one of the most reliable ways to lift a low mood and take the edge off stress and anxiety — something you feel in days, not decades. There is even genetic evidence that being more active *causes* lower rates of depression, not just that cheerful people happen to move more.

Move more, sit less (cont.)

One concrete, free option worth knowing about: **parkrun** — a free, weekly, timed 5 km run *or walk* in a local park, open to anyone and deliberately welcoming to complete beginners (plenty of people walk it). It rolls the two benefits into one cheap package: movement, plus a bit of outdoor social contact. It is a neat example of the whole idea — not "try harder," but a low-barrier default that makes the good choice easy.

Sleep like it matters

First, the fact that earns you a bit of fairness: **teenagers' body clocks genuinely run late.** As you go through puberty, the chemistry that makes you sleepy arrives later in the evening. A 15-year-old who can't fall asleep at 10pm isn't being lazy or difficult — they are being 15. That is biology, not a character flaw.

Sleep like it matters (cont.)

Now the useful part, and notice what it is *not*: it is not "sleep or you'll die young." The honest pitch is that **sleep is the best-evidenced short-term lever on how you actually feel** — your mood, your attention, your ability to handle a bad day. Lose sleep and those get measurably worse; get it back and they recover.

And the fix is often about the **environment, not effort**: when a real school pushed its start time later, students slept more and did better — nobody had to "try harder." So the fixable part isn't blaming yourself for the hours you can't get; it's protecting the ones you can.

Sleep like it matters (cont.)

The things that actually protect sleep are boringly practical, and they are about your surroundings more than your character: keep roughly regular hours, a dark and cool room, **dim the bright screens in the hour before bed** (bright evening light pushes your body clock even later), and keep caffeine — energy drinks especially — **out of the afternoon and evening** (it disrupts sleep even six hours before bed). None of that is willpower; it's just setting the stage.

Slip, slop, slap

Most items on this site are about risks decades away. **This one is different — it is already relevant to you.** Skin cancer called melanoma is one of the *commonest* cancers in people aged 15–34 in the UK. So this is one of the rare cases where "now" and "in fifty years" point the same way.

Two things worth knowing:

Slip, slop, slap (cont.)

- The action is genuinely trivial — sunscreen, a shirt, shade — and it is backed by an actual randomised trial, which is rarer than you'd think for this kind of advice.
- **Sunbeds are a Group 1 carcinogen** — the same top danger category as tobacco. A tan from a sunbed is selling you exactly the exposure the evidence warns against.

What you do now bends future risk in a clean way here: sun damage adds up over a lifetime, and in the trial the protection was still visible a decade after people stopped using the sunscreen. Small habit, lasting effect.

Change the rules, not just yourself

The whole site argues one point: change your **environment**, not your willpower. But someone builds that environment — and before long, that someone includes you.

The biggest health lever isn't only your own habits; it's the rules and the surroundings everyone shares. Real examples that worked: banning smoking indoors, a minimum price on alcohol, the "sugar tax" that made drinks less sweet, safer routes to cycle. None of these asked anyone to try harder — they changed the defaults for a whole population.

Change the rules, not just yourself (cont.)

So here is the honest, empowering version, and it is the opposite of "not my problem": **as you come of age, engaging and voting for governments and representatives who prioritise health-promoting environments becomes one of the highest-leverage health decisions you can make.**

Not to blame yourself for the environment you inherited — but to use the say you are about to get, for yourself and the people around you.

Trust, but verify.

Full evidence — with the study designs, the effect sizes, and the honest weaknesses — is on the site.

Information is power.